

Da Nang, 14 June 1968

Docteur Charrière,

I have finally obtained the object we discussed.

It is not a family piece, nor a recent copy. The men who brought it to me first claimed they had taken it from a house near the Citadel, but they changed that story once I began asking more precise questions. After two days of discussion and an additional payment, their leader admitted that the mask came from a storage site connected to the Hué collections, already damaged and poorly guarded since the fighting in February.

I cannot guarantee the full catalogue entry, but the label still attached inside the crate described it as a lacquered court object associated with the old imperial presentations. The thieves called it "the mask of Vishnu," probably because they heard the name somewhere and thought it would sound better to foreign buyers. I would be cautious with that identification. The piece is Vietnamese in its court use, even if certain details of the face and headdress have been interpreted, rightly or wrongly, as Indian or Cham.

The wood is old, heavy, with several visible repairs beneath the lacquer. Dominant colors: black, dark red, traces of gold. The surface has suffered: chips on the forehead, a slight crack along the right side, old or recent soot around the mouth. Nothing that would prevent display or restoration. On the contrary, these marks support the origin I was given.

The agreed price is confirmed. I added the necessary supplement to appease the two remaining intermediaries and prevent the object from reappearing in the hands of some passing dealer. You will understand that I do not wish to keep this piece in Da Nang any longer than necessary. Too many people are talking since Hué, and the cultural authorities have begun asking questions of antiquities dealers and transporters.

The crate will leave tomorrow morning under the ordinary designation "lacquerware - restoration," with two small worthless pieces placed above it for a quick inspection. It will be delivered in Saigon to the Crazy Horse Palace, in Cholon, as you instructed, to Monsieur Meng, who will then notify you upon arrival. I will not use your name on the transport sheet.

I advise you to have the piece transported quickly.

Respectfully,

Étienne Delmas

Antiquities, art objects, and private estates

Yen Bai Street, Da Nang